



...ctivill of 1.3 billion people to top the gold medal table ahead of their arch rival, the United States

Bang

By Sharda Ugra in Beijing

China invented both gunpowder and silk. It worked out that water could be put to use for tea as well as torture. It gave the world the idea of yin and yang. So, it's highly likely it could manage staging an Olympic Games on its own. Thanks for asking, though.

Sure, the Olympics is the Godzilla of sports events—10,500 athletes, 205 countries, 305 events, 5,600 accredited media, bless 'em all. But if you want to daunt China, large numbers is not the way to go. There's 1.3 billion of them to start with, and you don't want to know how many pairs of socks they go through in a year.

The numbers that can transfix China are far smaller, more elegant and loaded with meaning. At one time only the Emperor could use the '9'. The Mandarin word for '4' sounds too close to the word for 'death' so it has fallen out of favour with some when it comes to picking mobile phone numbers. And in a final conclusive, cosmic coincidence the digit that dominates the 29th Olympics has been distilled down to 8.